16.9.4 Rolling out verifiable credentials incrementally

Like any change in identity architecture, a gradual rollout is most effective. ACME used this incremental approach:

1. **Begin with a narrow use case.** External auditors are ideal: a well-defined group, clear policies, and strong external authorities (NISA).
2. **Stabilize verification processes.** Test presentation flows, revocation endpoints, and issuer trust rules across various devices and wallets.
3. **Expand to adjacent use cases.** Supplier delegations, clinician access, and field technicians become easier after the verification service and trust store are mature.
4. **Monitor policy outcomes.** Telemetry and decision logs help confirm that credential-based attributes function correctly in production.
5. **Iterate governance rules.** As issuers evolve, assurance levels and trust-store entries can be updated without altering policy logic.

This gradual adoption enabled ACME to expand credential-based authorization where it adds the most value while ensuring continuity in existing systems.

16.10 Summary

- Verifiable credentials offer portable, cryptographically verifiable claims that serve as trusted context in authorization decisions.
- Credential verification establishes *confidence* through cryptographic proofs and *trust* through evaluation of issuer authority and governance frameworks.
- Presentation protocols enable holders to respond selectively to attribute requests, supporting privacy-preserving access decisions.
- The trust triangle and trust diamond models explain how issuers, holders, verifiers, and governance authorities create end-to-end assurance.
- Trust stores track which issuers are recognized for specific credential types, distinguishing governance from policy logic.